NATIONAL INTEREST

Power defined in terms of national interest gives meaning to international politics. This realist proposition, propounded by Morgenthau, as the second and most important signpost of *realpolitik* may seem to be a little exaggerated but, nevertheless, it is true to some extent. It is the position of a particular state in the international arena by virtue of its national power that determines how it is going to exercise its will over others. When the question of will of a state comes into consideration, undoubtedly, the concept of national interest figures in one's own idea. But to pinpoint at certain basic national interests of any particular state it becomes very difficult. For, as Frankel[18] wrote 'National interest' is a singularly vague concept. It assumes a variety of meanings in the various contexts in which it is used and, despite its fundamental importance, these meanings cannot be reconciled. Hence, no agreement can be reached about its ultimate meaning.

However, certain attempts have been made to provide a bare meaning of the concept. This has been tried from subjective and an objective angle. The former interprets national interest as "a constantly changing pluralistic set of objective preferences", the latter assumes that national interest can be objectively defined, or at least, can be examined with the help of some objectively definable criteria.

Rosenau* had proposed a distinction between the use of the concept for the purpose of political analysis and that of political action. He was of the opinion that as an analytical tool, it can be employed to explain or evaluate the sources of adequacy of a nation's foreign policy, and as an instrument of political action, it can serve as a means for justifying, denouncing or proposing policies.

Frankel proposed a classification of the uses of the term 'national interest' into 'aspirational', 'operational', 'explanatory' and 'polemical'. On the aspirational level, national interest refers to some ideal set of goals, which the state would like to realize, if possible. At the operational level, national interest is the sum total of interests and policies actually pursued. On the 'explanatory' and 'polemical' level,